Coderblueprint

Java Backend Developer Interview Mastery Guide

A complete learning roadmap, topic map and interview question bank for freshers to 5 years of experience

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suvrat.agnihotri.1@gmail.com · Instagram @coderblueprint · facebook.com/Coderblueprint

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Interview-first usage

Audience: Java backend candidates from freshers through approximately 5 years of experience.

Core rule: learn a topic, implement a tiny example, explain it aloud, then answer one interview question without notes.

Priority	Meaning
P0	Must know for interviews in this track
P1	High-value for strong backend roles
P2	Differentiator as experience increases
LAB	Build or debug something instead of only reading

> ***Version checkpoint - 22 September 2026:*** *JDK 27 is the latest Java release and JDK 25 is the latest LTS. Spring Boot 4.1.1 is the latest stable Boot line shown in the current reference docs; it requires Java 17+ and Spring Framework 7.0.9+. The preparation strategy here is therefore: master Java 8 deeply, become fluent with Java 17/21 concepts, understand modern Java 25+ direction, and verify version-specific framework behavior for the target job.*

Experience-wise expectations

Experience	What interviewers usually test	Depth expected
0-1 YOE	Java, OOP, collections, SQL, DSA, basic Spring	Definition + example + correct code
1-2 YOE	Java 8+, Spring Boot, REST, JPA, SQL, testing	Internals of daily-use tools
2-3 YOE	Concurrency, transactions, security, Kafka, microservices	Failure handling + debugging
3-5 YOE	Architecture, scale, resilience, performance, ownership	Trade-offs + production reasoning

Fresher checklist

- OOP, inheritance, interfaces, abstract classes and composition.
- `equals/hashCode`, strings, collections, exceptions and generics.
- Java 8 lambdas, streams, Optional and functional interfaces.

- Arrays, strings, linked lists, stacks/queues, trees and basic dynamic programming.
- SQL joins, grouping, subqueries, indexes and transactions.
- Spring Boot DI, REST, validation and repository basics.

1-3 YOE checklist

- HashMap and ConcurrentHashMap internals.
- JVM memory and GC fundamentals.
- `synchronized`, `volatile`, atomics, executors and CompletableFuture.
- Spring bean lifecycle, AOP, proxies and `@Transactional`.
- JPA persistence context, dirty checking, lazy loading and N+1.
- Authentication/authorization, JWT/OAuth2 concepts.
- Kafka partitions, consumer groups, offsets and idempotency.
- Integration testing and production troubleshooting.

3-5 YOE checklist

- Service boundaries and data ownership.
- Timeouts, retries, circuit breaker, bulkhead and rate limiting.
- Saga, outbox, idempotency, eventual consistency.
- Observability: logs, metrics, traces, latency percentiles.
- JVM/DB/API performance diagnosis.
- System design with explicit assumptions and failure modes.
- Incident stories and architecture trade-offs.

> ***Interview habit:*** *answer design questions in this order: requirements → constraints → simple design → data model → API/messages → failures → scale → security → observability → trade-offs.*

Java core

Java is the base layer for the whole backend stack. Framework knowledge is much easier once the language and runtime are solid.

Language fundamentals - P0

Topic	Learn deeply
OOP	Encapsulation, abstraction, inheritance, polymorphism, composition
Types	Primitive/reference, widening/narrowing, boxing/unboxing
Pass-by-value	Object references are values that are copied
Access	`private`, package, `protected`, `public`
Constructors	Chaining, initialization order, private constructors
`final`	Final variables, methods, classes
`static`	Class members, static hiding, initialization
`this` / `super`	Constructor/method/field access
Equality	`==`, `equals`, `hashCode`
Immutability	Final state, defensive copies, safe sharing

High-priority Java questions

Question	Strong answer should include
Is Java pass-by-reference?	No. Java is pass-by-value; for objects the copied value is a reference. Demonstrate mutation vs reassignment.
`==` vs `equals()`?	Identity/reference comparison vs logical equality.
Why must equal objects have equal hash codes?	Hash-based collections use hash code to find candidate buckets, then equality to confirm.
Can private methods be overridden?	No; they are not dynamically overridable inherited methods.
Can static methods be overridden?	No; they are hidden.
Can final methods be overloaded?	Yes. `final` prevents overriding, not overloading.
Composition vs inheritance?	Composition favors replaceable behavior and lower coupling; inheritance should represent a genuine subtype.

Question	Strong answer should include
Why is String immutable?	Pooling/sharing, security, thread-safety and stable hash value are major reasons.
What is covariant return type?	An overriding method can return a subtype of the original return type.
What is initialization order?	Static superclass/subclass initialization, instance initialization, constructor chaining and object construction.

Strings - P0

Study:

- String pool, literals, `intern()`, `new String(...)`.
- `StringBuilder` vs `StringBuffer`.
- Concatenation in loops.
- `isBlank`, `strip`, `lines`, joining and formatted output.
- Unicode awareness for text processing.

Generics - P0/P1

Study invariance, wildcards, PECS, generic methods, bounds, raw types and type erasure.

Question	What to explain
Why is `List<String>` not `List<Object>`?	Generic types are invariant.
`extends` vs `super` wildcard?	`extends` for producers, `super` for consumers.
What is type erasure?	Generic type information is primarily enforced at compile time; runtime restrictions follow from erasure.
Why avoid raw types?	They bypass generic type safety and can defer errors to runtime.

Exceptions - P0

Know checked vs unchecked, try/catch/finally, try-with-resources, `AutoCloseable`, suppression, custom exceptions and exception translation.

Question	Answer target
Can `finally` change a return?	Yes, a `return` in `finally` can override the pending return/exception.
`throw` vs `throws`?	Throwing an exception instance vs declaring possible propagation.
Why not catch `Exception` everywhere?	It hides the recovery boundary and can swallow programming errors.
What is exception chaining?	Preserve the original cause while translating to a higher-level exception.

Modern Java roadmap

Version family	Interview topics
Java 8	Lambdas, functional interfaces, method references, Streams, Optional, `java.time`
Java 9-11	Modules concept, `var`, collection factories, HTTP Client, newer String APIs
Java 12-17	Switch expressions, text blocks, records, sealed classes, pattern matching for `instanceof`
Java 21	Virtual threads, record patterns, pattern matching for switch, sequenced collections
Java 22-25	Platform direction and role-relevant APIs; know how to check release status
Java 26-27	Release awareness; focus on practical use rather than JEP memorization

Collections, Streams and functional Java

Collections are high-yield because they combine Java API knowledge, complexity and data-structure reasoning.

Collections map

Type	Core implementations	Interview focus
List	ArrayList, LinkedList	Resizing, index access, insertion and locality
Set	HashSet, LinkedHashSet, TreeSet	Uniqueness, hashing, ordering
Map	HashMap, LinkedHashMap, TreeMap, ConcurrentHashMap	Hashing, ordering, concurrency
Queue	ArrayDeque, PriorityQueue	FIFO/LIFO, heap behavior
Concurrent	ConcurrentHashMap, blocking queues, CopyOnWriteArrayList	Workload-specific concurrency

HashMap internals - P0

Understand:

- Hashing to buckets.
- Equality checks after locating candidate entries.
- Collision handling and treeified bins in modern implementations.
- Resize/rehash concepts.
- Mutable-key hazards.
- Why `ConcurrentHashMap` is not just a globally synchronized HashMap.

Collections interview questions

Question	Strong answer should include
ArrayList vs LinkedList?	ArrayList is usually the default due to indexing/cache locality; LinkedList has node overhead and poor locality.
HashMap vs Hashtable?	HashMap is modern/non-synchronized; Hashtable is legacy.

Question	Strong answer should include
TreeMap vs HashMap?	Sorted tree-based operations vs hash-based lookup.
Comparable vs Comparator?	Natural ordering vs external/custom ordering.
What if a key's hashCode changes?	Lookup can fail because the key may be searched in a different bucket.
Why can different objects have the same hash?	Finite hash space means collisions are expected.
What is fail-fast iteration?	Many iterators detect structural modification and throw rather than promise weakly consistent results.

Streams - P0

Learn the pipeline model:

1. Source.
2. Intermediate lazy operations.
3. Terminal operation.

Must know: `map`, `filter`, `flatMap`, `distinct`, `sorted`, `limit`, `skip`, `findFirst`, `findAny`, `collect`, `groupingBy`, `partitioningBy`, `mapping`, `counting`, `joining`, `reduce`.

Stream questions

Question	What to cover
`map` vs `flatMap`?	One-to-one transformation vs flattening nested streams.
Intermediate vs terminal?	Lazy pipeline construction vs execution/result.
Why are streams lazy?	Avoid unnecessary work and enable pipeline fusion.
`findFirst` vs `findAny`?	Ordered first result vs any result.
`reduce` vs `collect`?	Immutable-style aggregation vs mutable reduction into containers.
Why avoid side effects?	Harder reasoning, especially in parallel pipelines.
When use a loop instead?	Complex control flow, readability, debugging or stateful logic.

LAB

- Word frequency with HashMap.
- Group employees by department.
- First non-repeated character.
- LRU cache.
- Concurrent frequency counter.
- Compare loops, sequential streams and parallel streams.

Concurrency, multithreading and JVM

Concurrency questions become more practical as experience grows. Learn API usage and the Java Memory Model together.

Threading fundamentals - P0

- Thread lifecycle and states.
- `start()` creates/schedules a separate execution path; `run()` is an ordinary method call when invoked directly.
- `synchronized` gives mutual exclusion and visibility/ordering.
- `volatile` gives visibility/ordering but not compound-action atomicity.
- Atomic classes provide specific atomic state transitions.
- Explicit locks can provide `tryLock`, interruptible acquisition and conditions.

JMM checklist

Concept	Meaning
Visibility	A thread sees another thread's writes
Atomicity	An operation behaves indivisibly
Ordering	Reordering is constrained by the memory model
Happens-before	Formal visibility/ordering relationship
Data race	Conflicting unsynchronized accesses, at least one a write
Safe publication	Object is made visible without exposing partial construction

Executors and async APIs - P0/P1

Learn `ExecutorService`, `Callable`, `Future`, `CompletableFuture`, ForkJoinPool, bounded queues, shutdown and interruption.

Concurrency questions

Question	Strong answer
`synchronized` vs `volatile`?	Mutual exclusion + visibility vs visibility/ordering without mutual exclusion.
Why is `i++` unsafe concurrently?	Read-modify-write is not one atomic action.
How fix race conditions?	Lock, atomic operation, immutability, message passing or another correct coordination strategy.
Deadlock vs livelock vs starvation?	Circular waiting vs active non-progress vs indefinite resource denial.
How diagnose deadlock?	Thread dump → blocked threads → lock ownership → cycle → code path.
Why use executors?	Reuse, bounded concurrency, queueing and lifecycle management.
Future vs CompletableFuture?	Result handle vs composable async/error pipeline.
When use virtual threads?	Large numbers of concurrent blocking I/O tasks; not a CPU-speedup tool.
What is structured concurrency?	Treat related concurrent tasks as one unit for cancellation, error handling and observability.

JVM architecture - P0/P1

Area	Study
Class loading	Loading, linking, initialization, delegation
Memory	Heap, thread stacks, metaspace, native/direct memory
Execution	Interpreter and JIT
GC	Reachability, throughput/latency, G1 and ZGC awareness
Diagnostics	`jcmd`, `jstack`, heap dumps, GC logs, JFR
Performance	CPU, allocation, locks, GC, I/O, DB latency

JVM questions

- Heap vs stack?
- What is a classloader leak?

- What causes different `OutOfMemoryError` categories?
- What is a Java memory leak?
- Why can GC affect tail latency?
- How investigate high CPU?
- How investigate high memory?

> ***LAB:*** *Write a race condition, fix it using* `synchronized` *and* `AtomicInteger`*, then create a deadlock and diagnose it from a thread dump.*

DSA and coding rounds

Coding rounds are about reasoning, implementation and complexity, not framework trivia.

DSA curriculum

Area	Topics
Arrays/Strings	Two pointers, sliding window, prefix sums, frequency maps
Linked list	Reverse, cycle, merge, fast/slow pointers
Stack/Queue	Monotonic stack, deque, BFS
Hashing	Counting, lookup, grouping, deduplication
Trees	DFS/BFS, BST, traversal, LCA
Heap	Top-K, merge-K, scheduling
Graphs	BFS, DFS, topological sort, shortest path, DSU
Backtracking	Subsets, permutations, combinations
Greedy	Intervals, scheduling
DP	1D/2D, subsequences, knapsack
Search/Sort	Binary search, merge/quick sort, counting/bucket/radix concepts

50 high-value coding problems

1. Two Sum
2. Best Time to Buy and Sell Stock
3. Valid Anagram
4. Group Anagrams
5. Longest Substring Without Repeating Characters
6. Longest Consecutive Sequence
7. Product of Array Except Self
8. Maximum Subarray
9. Merge Intervals

10. 3Sum
11. Container With Most Water
12. Valid Parentheses
13. Min Stack
14. Daily Temperatures
15. Sliding Window Maximum
16. Reverse Linked List
17. Merge Two Sorted Lists
18. Linked List Cycle
19. Remove Nth Node From End
20. Reorder List
21. LRU Cache
22. Binary Tree Inorder Traversal
23. Maximum Depth of Binary Tree
24. Level Order Traversal
25. Validate BST
26. Lowest Common Ancestor
27. Diameter of Binary Tree
28. Serialize/Deserialize Binary Tree
29. Kth Largest Element
30. Top K Frequent Elements
31. Merge K Sorted Lists
32. Number of Islands
33. Clone Graph
34. Course Schedule
35. Shortest Path in a Grid
36. Network Delay Time
37. Number of Connected Components
38. Subsets
39. Permutations
40. Combination Sum
41. House Robber
42. Coin Change
43. Longest Increasing Subsequence
44. 0/1 Knapsack

45. Edit Distance
46. Next Greater Element
47. Queue Using Stacks
48. Insert Interval
49. Meeting Rooms / Scheduling
50. Trie-based prefix search

Coding explanation template

1. Clarify assumptions.
2. Give a simple correct approach.
3. State time/space complexity.
4. Code cleanly.
5. Test edge cases.
6. Optimize only after correctness.

Spring Core

Spring interviews should test the container, not annotation memorization.

Core topics - P0

- IoC and dependency injection.
- `ApplicationContext`.
- Bean scopes.
- Constructor vs setter vs field injection.
- `@Configuration`, `@Bean`, component scanning.
- Profiles and configuration.
- Bean lifecycle.
- `BeanPostProcessor`.
- AOP, proxies, advice and pointcuts.

Spring interview questions

Question	Answer target
What is IoC?	Creation and assembly of objects are delegated to a container.
Why constructor injection?	Explicit required dependencies, final fields, easy testing.
What is a Spring bean?	Object managed by the container.
`@Component` / `@Service` / `@Repository`?	Stereotype semantics; repository also supports exception translation.
What if two beans match?	Qualifier, primary/default selection or explicit injection design.
Spring singleton vs GoF singleton?	One instance per ApplicationContext vs global singleton pattern.
Circular dependency?	Dependency cycle; redesign is preferable where possible.
What is a proxy?	Intercepts method calls to add framework behavior.
Why can self-invocation break advice?	Call bypasses the proxy.
What is lazy initialization?	Bean creation is delayed until needed.

> ***Interview must-know:*** *Spring's declarative transaction implementation is proxy-based and uses transaction interception. Know this mechanism instead of describing* `@Transactional` *as a magical annotation.*

Spring Boot, REST and production design

Spring Boot map - P0/P1

Topic	Study
Auto-configuration	Conditional configuration, classpath, existing beans
Starters	Dependency grouping and conventions
Configuration	Properties/YAML, profiles, binding, externalized config
REST MVC	DispatcherServlet, request mapping, serialization
Validation	DTO validation and error contracts
Exception handling	`@ExceptionHandler`, `@ControllerAdvice`
Actuator	Health, metrics, management endpoints
Observability	Logs, metrics, traces, correlation IDs
AOT/native image	Native deployment differences and reflection constraints

Request flow

Client → Filters → DispatcherServlet → Controller → Service → Repository/External API

Know where authentication, validation, transactions, serialization and exception handling fit.

REST questions

Question	Answer target
PUT vs PATCH?	Replacement-style/idempotent semantics vs partial modification.
POST vs PUT?	Server-side creation/processing vs known resource URI update semantics.
Idempotency?	Repeating the operation produces the same intended result; use idempotency keys where needed.
401 vs 403?	Authentication failure vs authorization failure.

Question	Answer target
Validation error response?	Consistent 4xx contract with safe details.
How design API errors?	Stable error code, message, field details, correlation ID, no sensitive internals.
How version APIs?	Consistent strategy + compatibility/deprecation plan.

Production questions

- How would you troubleshoot a slow endpoint?
- What causes DB connection-pool exhaustion?
- What is backpressure?
- What should liveness and readiness mean?
- How do you secure Actuator endpoints?
- How do you trace one request across services?

> ***Current observability direction:*** *Spring Boot describes observability as logging, metrics and traces and uses Micrometer Observation for metrics/tracing integration.*

Spring Security and API security

Core security topics

- Authentication vs authorization.
- Session vs token authentication.
- JWT structure and validation.
- OAuth2 roles and access/refresh tokens.
- OIDC and ID tokens.
- CSRF and CORS.
- Password hashing.
- Resource-level authorization.
- Secure secret management.
- Rate limiting and abuse protection.

Spring Security request flow

HTTP request → Security filter chain → Authentication → Authorization → Controller

Security questions

Question	Answer target
Authentication vs authorization?	Who you are vs what you may do.
What is `SecurityContextHolder`?	Holder for the current security context/authentication.
JWT vs session?	Stateless verification vs server-side state; discuss revocation/scaling trade-offs.
Access vs refresh token?	API access credential vs token-renewal credential with stronger protection needs.
Why validate issuer/audience/expiry?	Signature alone is not sufficient; claims constrain acceptance.
What is CSRF?	Cross-site request using ambient credentials such as cookies.
What is CORS?	Browser origin policy; not an authentication mechanism.

Question	Answer target
Why object-level authorization?	Being authenticated does not imply access to arbitrary resource IDs.
Why avoid logging JWTs/ passwords?	Credentials must not become persistent secrets in logs.

> ***OWASP checkpoint:*** *the API Security Top 10 includes broken object-level authorization, broken authentication, broken object-property authorization and unrestricted resource consumption. Use these as review questions for any API.*

SQL, JPA and Hibernate

SQL comes before ORM. Interviewers often probe what Hibernate is doing underneath the repository abstraction.

SQL curriculum

Topic	Priority
SELECT, WHERE, ORDER BY, NULLs	P0
Joins	P0
GROUP BY/HAVING	P0
Subqueries/EXISTS/CTEs	P1
Indexes	P0
EXPLAIN/query plans	P0
ACID and transactions	P0
Isolation and locks	P0
Normalization	P1
Pagination	P1

SQL questions

Question	Answer target
WHERE vs HAVING?	Row filtering before grouping vs group filtering after aggregation.
INNER vs LEFT JOIN?	Matching rows vs preserving all rows on the left side.
Composite index?	Multiple-column index; order matters.
Why not index everything?	Storage + write/maintenance cost.
Covering index?	Query can be satisfied from index columns without base-table access where supported.

Question	Answer target
Isolation level?	Defines visibility of concurrent transaction effects.
Deadlock?	Transactions waiting on resources held by each other.
Offset vs keyset pagination?	Simplicity vs scalable stable traversal on a sorted key.

JPA/Hibernate topics

- Entity states: transient, managed, detached, removed.
- Persistence context.
- Dirty checking.
- Lazy/eager fetching.
- N+1 problem.
- Cascades and orphan removal.
- JPQL and native SQL.
- Projections.
- Pagination and scrolling.
- Optimistic/pessimistic locking.
- First- and second-level cache.
- Auditing.

JPA questions

Question	Strong answer
Entity vs DTO?	Persistence model vs API/use-case model.
Persistence context?	Managed entity identity and unit-of-work scope.
Dirty checking?	Detect managed changes and write them during flush.
Why N+1?	Parent query + per-parent relationship query.
How fix N+1?	Fetch join, EntityGraph, batch fetch or query redesign.
LazyInitializationException?	Lazy state accessed outside active persistence context.
`save` vs `saveAndFlush`?	Immediate flush vs normal synchronization timing; flush is not commit.

Question	Strong answer
Optimistic vs pessimistic locking?	Version conflict detection vs DB locking.
Why projections?	Less data, less materialization, better read-model alignment.

Transactions - deep questions

Question	Answer target
ACID?	Atomicity, Consistency, Isolation, Durability with examples.
What does `@Transactional` do?	Proxy starts/joins transaction, invokes target, then commits/rolls back according to rules.
Propagation?	How method participates in existing transaction or creates another; know REQUIRED and REQUIRES_NEW.
Isolation?	Visibility rules for concurrent work; know DB-specific defaults.
Rollback rules?	Depends on exception/configuration; not every exception means rollback.
Why keep transactions small?	Long locks/connections increase contention; avoid slow remote calls inside DB transactions when possible.

> ***Database checkpoint:*** *MySQL 8.4 documents four InnoDB isolation levels: READ UNCOMMITTED, READ COMMITTED, REPEATABLE READ and SERIALIZABLE, with REPEATABLE READ as the default.*

Microservices, distributed systems and resilience

The key shift from 2-5 YOE is moving from local correctness to correctness under partial failure.

Microservice topics

- Service boundaries and data ownership.
- REST and synchronous communication.
- Asynchronous events.
- API Gateway.
- Service discovery.
- Externalized configuration.
- Timeouts.
- Retries and backoff.
- Circuit breaker.
- Bulkhead.
- Rate limiting.
- Saga.
- Outbox.
- Idempotency.
- Eventual consistency.
- Observability.

Distributed-systems questions

Question	Answer target
Why can a healthy service call fail?	Network/DNS/LB/pool/timeout/overload/client-side failures.
Why mandatory timeouts?	Prevent resource exhaustion and cascading failures.
When retry?	Bounded, transient, safe-to-retry failures.
Why can retries worsen outages?	Retry storms multiply load.

Question	Answer target
Circuit breaker?	Stop repeated calls to failing dependency and probe recovery.
Saga choreography vs orchestration?	Decentralized event flow vs coordinator-driven workflow.
Outbox pattern?	Business state + event record in one local DB transaction, then asynchronous publish.
Duplicate messages?	Idempotent consumer or deduplication by stable event/business ID.
Exactly once?	Scope the guarantee; transport-level guarantees do not automatically make external side effects exactly once.
Eventual consistency?	Temporary divergence with convergence after propagation.

Resilience4j concepts

Know the purpose of:

- CircuitBreaker: protect from repeated failures.
- Retry: bounded transient-failure retries.
- RateLimiter: control request frequency.
- Bulkhead: isolate concurrency.
- TimeLimiter: bound async duration.

Kafka and event-driven systems

Kafka vocabulary - P0

Concept	Interview meaning
Topic	Logical stream of records
Partition	Ordering + parallelism unit
Offset	Position in partition
Producer	Publishes records
Consumer	Reads and commits progress
Consumer group	Shares partition work
Rebalance	Partition ownership changes
Retention	Record lifetime policy
Compaction	Retain latest value per key
Replication	Copies partitions for fault tolerance
Transactions	Atomic producer/offset behavior in supported patterns

Kafka questions

Question	Answer target
Where is ordering guaranteed?	Within a partition.
Why message key?	Route related messages to same partition for per-key ordering.
Consumers > partitions?	Extra consumers are idle in that group.
Consumer lag?	Producer progress minus consumer progress/commit position.
At-most-once vs at-least-once?	Potential loss vs potential duplicates.

Question	Answer target
Crash after DB commit but before offset commit?	Redelivery; consumer must be idempotent or atomically integrated.
Poison message?	Bounded retry, DLQ/recovery, observability and reprocessing plan.
How choose partitions?	Throughput, parallelism, ordering, growth and operational cost.

> ***Kafka semantics checkpoint:*** *Kafka's design documentation distinguishes at-most-once, at-least-once and exactly-once processing and explains transactions around produced records and consumer offsets.*

Spring Kafka topics

- Listener container and acknowledgment modes.
- Consumer concurrency.
- Error handlers and backoff.
- Dead-letter topics.
- Serialization and schema evolution.
- Transactions.
- Idempotent consumers.
- Integration tests with a real broker/container.

Testing strategy

Testing reveals whether you understand system boundaries.

Test layers

Layer	Use
Unit	Fast isolated logic
Slice	Framework-slice behavior
Integration	Real DB/broker/framework interaction
E2E	Critical business journeys
Contract	Producer/consumer compatibility

Testing questions

Question	Strong answer
Unit vs integration?	Isolated unit behavior vs real component interaction.
What should be mocked?	External behavior not owned by the unit; avoid mocking every internal class.
Why too much mocking?	Tests become coupled to implementation and may miss real integration failures.
Parameterized tests?	Reuse one test with many inputs.
How test rollback?	Force expected failure and assert post-transaction state.
How test duplicate Kafka delivery?	Deliver duplicate event and assert one state transition.
How test retries/timeouts?	Inject delays/failures and assert retry boundaries and non-retryable paths.

Testcontainers - P1

Use real database/broker containers when correctness depends on database dialect, locking, isolation, indexes or messaging semantics.

Docker, CI/CD, Kubernetes and cloud

Docker

Topic	Learn
Image vs container	Template vs running instance
Dockerfile	Base image, layers, entrypoint/cmd
Cache	Layer reuse/invalidation
Multi-stage builds	Build environment separated from runtime
Networking	Container connectivity/service naming
Security	Minimal images, secrets, least privilege

Docker questions

- Why multi-stage builds?
- `COPY` vs `ADD`?
- `CMD` vs `ENTRYPOINT`?
- Why should images be small?
- What is a container not?

Kubernetes minimum

Pod, Deployment, ReplicaSet, Service, ConfigMap, Secret, Ingress/Gateway, readiness/liveness, resource requests/limits, rolling deployment, service discovery and troubleshooting.

CI/CD and Git

Question	Answer target
What should a backend pipeline do?	Compile, test, quality/security checks, package, image build, scan, publish, deploy.
Merge vs rebase?	Preserve history vs rewrite commits onto a new base.
Reset vs revert?	Move branch pointer/rewrite history vs create a compensating commit.

Question	Answer target
Rollback?	Restore known-good app version while considering backward-compatible data migrations.

Cloud basics

Compute, containers, serverless, object storage, relational DB, DNS, load balancing, network segmentation, IAM, TLS, observability, backups, multi-zone reliability and cost optimization.

> ***AWS architecture lens:*** *the current AWS Well-Architected Framework uses six pillars: operational excellence, security, reliability, performance efficiency, cost optimization and sustainability.*

System design

At 3-5 YOE, system design is about assumptions, trade-offs and failure behavior.

Design sequence

1. Functional requirements.
2. Non-functional requirements.
3. Traffic/storage estimates.
4. Components and boundaries.
5. Data model and indexes.
6. Sync vs async communication.
7. Cache strategy.
8. Failure behavior.
9. Security.
10. Observability.
11. Trade-offs and future evolution.

High-value system design questions

Question	Key discussion points
URL shortener	ID generation, redirect latency, cache, storage, abuse
Rate limiter	Token bucket/sliding window, distributed state, hot keys
Order system	State machine, inventory/payment, outbox, saga
Notification system	Queueing, fan-out, retries, provider limits
File upload	Object storage, signed URLs, scanning, async processing
Job scheduler	Durable jobs, worker leasing, retries, deduplication
Audit log	Append-only storage, integrity, retention, query
API gateway	Routing, auth, rate limiting, observability
Payment system	Idempotency, reconciliation, provider uncertainty

Architecture building blocks

- **Cache:** define staleness and invalidation.
- **Queue:** define delivery semantics and replay.
- **Replica:** define acceptable lag.
- **Sharding:** choose partition key and address hot partitions.
- **Search index:** identify source of truth and index lag.
- **Object storage:** define access, lifecycle and scanning.

Design patterns, SOLID and clean code

Patterns are useful when they solve a real design problem.

SOLID

Principle	Interview explanation
S	One cohesive reason to change
O	Add behavior with minimal modification to stable code
L	Subtypes preserve base-type behavioral expectations
I	Focused interfaces
D	High-level policy depends on abstractions

High-value patterns

Pattern	Recognize when
Strategy	Interchangeable behaviors/algorithms
Factory Method	Varying object creation
Abstract Factory	Families of related objects
Builder	Many optional parameters/readable construction
Adapter	Interface mismatch
Facade	Complex subsystem simplification
Decorator	Dynamic behavior extension
Proxy	Access control/lazy loading/caching/security
Observer	Event notification
Template Method	Stable algorithm with variable steps
Chain of Responsibility	Sequential handlers

Pattern	Recognize when
Command	Operation as an object
State	State-dependent behavior
Singleton	Centralized instance control; know downsides

Pattern questions

- You have 20 payment-provider `if/else` branches. What abstraction might help?
- Builder or constructor?
- Strategy vs State?
- Adapter vs Facade?
- When is Singleton a code smell?
- Where does a Proxy pattern appear in Spring?

Project deep-dive and behavioral interviews

Anything on your resume can be interviewed.

Project explanation template

1. Business problem.
2. Users/traffic.
3. Architecture.
4. One critical request flow.
5. One data flow.
6. Security model.
7. Reliability strategy.
8. Observability.
9. Hardest incident.
10. One trade-off and what you would improve today.

Project questions

Question	Strong answer
Why microservices?	Real business/team/technical driver + distributed cost.
Why Kafka instead of REST?	Decoupling, buffering, fan-out, async processing when needed.
Why MySQL/PostgreSQL?	Workload, integrity, transactions, ecosystem.
Where are transaction boundaries?	What must be atomic vs asynchronous.
Hardest bug?	Symptom → evidence → root cause → fix → prevention.
What performance issue did you solve?	Real metric, bottleneck, change, outcome.
What would you redesign?	Concrete limitation + trade-off.
How handle duplicate events?	Actual idempotency rule/key.
How secure service-to-service calls?	Identity, auth, TLS, rotation, audit.

Question	Strong answer
How deploy?	Pipeline, image, config, rollout, rollback.

Behavioral questions

- Tell me about yourself.
- Why are you looking for a change?
- Tell me about a disagreement.
- Tell me about a failure.
- Tell me about an incident you owned.
- How do you prioritize under pressure?
- How do you learn a new technology?
- What is the most important technical trade-off you made?
- Tell me about a time you improved performance.
- Tell me about a time you reduced operational risk.

Master interview question bank

Fresher / entry-level

- Four pillars of OOP?
- Overloading vs overriding?
- Interface default method?
- ArrayList internal structure?
- HashMap lookup flow?
- HashSet uniqueness?
- String vs StringBuilder?
- Checked vs unchecked exception?
- `map/filter/reduce` ?
- What is a lambda?
- What is Optional?
- Inner class vs static nested class?
- `final` variable/method/class?
- SQL joins?
- Primary vs unique key?
- Normalization?
- What is REST?
- What is dependency injection?
- What is Spring Boot?

1-3 YOE

- Why can `@Transactional` fail on self-invocation?
- How does Spring create a bean?
- How does Boot auto-configuration work?
- N+1 query - causes and fixes?
- What is optimistic locking?
- What causes connection-pool exhaustion?
- What is a circuit breaker?
- Kafka partition vs consumer group?
- At-least-once delivery?

- JWT access token validation?
- Unit vs integration test?
- How do you debug a slow endpoint?
- How do you trace a request across services?
- Why can retries worsen an outage?
- When should you use keyset pagination?

3-5 YOE

- How choose microservice boundaries?
- How maintain consistency across services?
- How make consumers idempotent?
- When use virtual threads?
- How tune JVM performance?
- How prevent retry storms?
- How evolve event schemas?
- How roll out a breaking DB change?
- What would you monitor for Kafka consumers?
- How investigate a production incident?
- How design for partial failure?
- When use cache vs read replica?
- When is eventual consistency acceptable?
- How design API authorization?
- How do you estimate capacity before choosing infrastructure?

Tricky "what happens if..." questions

Scenario	Expected reasoning
Call `run()` instead of `start()`	Current thread executes it; no new thread
`finally` returns	Can override pending return/exception
HashMap key changes	Lookup can fail
Offset committed before processing	Crash can lose business processing
Offset committed after processing	Crash can duplicate business processing

Scenario	Expected reasoning
Slow remote call inside DB transaction	Holds DB resources unnecessarily
Circuit breaker too sensitive	May reject healthy traffic
Huge DB pool	Can overload database
Index every field	More write/storage cost
Cache never expires	Stale data and memory growth

12-week preparation roadmap

Weeks 1-4 - Java + DSA

Week	Focus	Output
1	OOP, language, strings, exceptions, generics	50 Java questions + 10 problems
2	Collections, HashMap, ordering	15 collection questions + 10 problems
3	Streams, Optional, functional Java	10 coding/stream tasks
4	Arrays, strings, linked list, stack/queue	15-20 timed problems

Weeks 5-8 - Spring + data

Week	Focus	Output
5	Spring Core, DI, lifecycle, AOP, transactions	Explain bean creation and `@Transactional`
6	Spring Boot, REST, validation	CRUD API with tests
7	SQL, indexes, transactions, EXPLAIN	30 SQL queries + 5 plans
8	JPA/Hibernate, fetch, N+1, locking	Fix N+1 + implement optimistic lock

Weeks 9-12 - distributed backend

Week	Focus	Output
9	Security + API security	Secure an API + explain flow
10	Kafka + microservices + resilience	Event workflow + idempotency
11	Docker + testing + observability + cloud	Containerize + integration tests
12	Mock interviews + system design + project	3 tech mocks + 2 coding mocks + 2 designs

Daily study split

Mode	Fresher	1-3 YOE	3-5 YOE
Concepts	35%	30%	25%
Coding	35%	25%	20%
Backend/project	20%	30%	30%
System design/behavioral	10%	15%	25%

Final 7 days

1. Java + collections + streams.
2. Concurrency + JVM.
3. Spring + Boot + REST + transactions.
4. SQL + JPA + performance.
5. Security + Kafka + microservices.
6. Coding mock + system design + project walkthrough.
7. Resume-driven questions + behavioral + weak areas.

> ***Final-week rule:*** *depth in technologies named by the target role is more valuable than shallow memorization of many extra tools.*

Final interview checklist

Java

- OOP, equality, immutability, strings, generics, exceptions.
- Collections and complexity.
- Streams, lambdas, Optional.
- Concurrency, JMM, executors, CompletableFuture.
- JVM memory, GC, diagnostics.
- Java 8 baseline + Java 17/21 + Java 25 LTS awareness + Java 27 release awareness.

Spring

- IoC/DI, bean lifecycle, scopes, AOP/proxies.
- Auto-configuration and request lifecycle.
- Validation and error handling.
- Transactions and propagation/isolation.
- Spring Security flow.
- Actuator, metrics and tracing.

Data

- Joins, aggregation, indexes, EXPLAIN.
- Transactions, isolation, locks, deadlocks.
- Entity state, dirty checking, N+1, fetch plans, locking, pagination.

Distributed backend

- Service boundaries.
- Timeouts, retries, circuit breaker, bulkhead, rate limiting.
- Kafka partitions, offsets, consumer groups, delivery semantics.
- Outbox, saga, idempotency, eventual consistency.
- Observability and incident response.

Delivery

- Docker and multi-stage builds.

- CI/CD and Git.
- Kubernetes minimum concepts.
- Cloud networking, IAM, storage, reliability, cost.

Communication

- Answer directly first.
- Use a concrete example.
- State assumptions.
- Explain trade-offs.
- For incidents: symptom → evidence → root cause → fix → prevention.

> ***Strong-signal rule:*** *senior communication is not more jargon. It is clear assumptions, measurable reasoning, trade-offs and anticipation of failure.*

Research basis and current reference map

The current-platform portions of this guide were verified against primary documentation around 22 September 2026.

Java

- Oracle JDK release notes index: https://www.oracle.com/java/technologies/javase/jdk-relnotes-index.html
- JDK 27 release notes: https://www.oracle.com/java/technologies/javase/27-relnote-issues.html
- Oracle Java SE Support Roadmap: https://www.oracle.com/de/java/technologies/java-se-support-roadmap.html
- Java 21 pattern matching: https://docs.oracle.com/en/java/javase/21/language/pattern-matching.html
- JDK 25 structured concurrency: https://docs.oracle.com/en/java/javase/25/core/structured-concurrency.html

Spring

- Spring Boot System Requirements: https://docs.spring.io/spring-boot/system-requirements.html
- Spring Boot Reference: https://docs.spring.io/spring-boot/4.0/reference/index.html
- Spring transaction internals: https://docs.spring.io/spring-framework/reference/data-access/transaction/declarative/tx-decl-explained.html
- Spring Security Reference: https://docs.spring.io/spring-security/reference/
- Spring Security authentication architecture: https://docs.spring.io/spring-security/reference/servlet/authentication/architecture.html
- Spring Data JPA query methods: https://docs.spring.io/spring-data/jpa/reference/jpa-query-methods.html
- Spring Boot observability: https://docs.spring.io/spring-boot/reference/actuator/observability.html
- Spring Boot metrics: https://docs.spring.io/spring-boot/reference/actuator/metrics.html
- Spring Boot native image: https://docs.spring.io/spring-boot/reference/packaging/native-image/introducing-graalvm-native-images.html

Kafka, testing and delivery

- Apache Kafka design: https://kafka.apache.org/41/design/design/

- Testcontainers Java guide: https://testcontainers.com/guides/getting-started-with-testcontainers-for-java/
- JUnit 5 User Guide: https://junit.org/junit5/docs/current/user-guide/
- Docker multi-stage builds: https://docs.docker.com/get-started/docker-concepts/building-images/multi-stage-builds/
- Docker Engine security: https://docs.docker.com/engine/security/
- Maven lifecycle: https://maven.apache.org/guides/introduction/introduction-to-the-lifecycle

Security and cloud

- OWASP API Security Project: https://owasp.org/projects/api-security-project
- OWASP API Security Top 10: https://api-security.owasp.org/editions/2023/en/0x11-t10/
- AWS Well-Architected Framework: https://docs.aws.amazon.com/wellarchitected/latest/framework/the-pillars-of-the-framework.html
- AWS Well-Architected questions: https://docs.aws.amazon.com/wellarchitected/latest/framework/appendix.html

> ***Research note:*** *Primary vendor/framework documentation was preferred for current platform facts. The question bank is a curated interview-learning set, not a measured ranking of every employer's questions.*

Thanks for reading

Follow Coderblueprint for more Java, Spring Boot, microservices, system design and interview preparation content.

suvrat.agnihotri.1@gmail.com · Instagram @coderblueprint · facebook.com/Coderblueprint